of young men vowed to follow Ashfaq's example in the swelling ranks of Kashmir's Azaadi fighters. Kalashnikov rifles and military training were provided to JKLF mujahideen in Azad Kashmir, and most of these young fighters optimistically believed India would soon be forced to relax its grip in frustration at the growing signs and sounds of violent opposition that spread across the Vale. Some imagined that Pakistan would attack first to help liberate them. Neither happened. The more resisters emerged in the heyday of this revolution, the more their leaders disagreed over tactics and strategy instead of uniting behind a single respected head or council of like-minded Azaadis. Several promising attempts were made to unify the competing Azaadis, the best of which was the creation of the All-Parties Hurriyat (Liberation) Conference (APHC), which brought together over thirty leaders.

Pakistan's ISI paid and trained the most militant Islamic fundamentalists sent across the Line of Control, members of Hafiz M. Sayeed's Lashkar-e-Taiyba (LeT), who attacked as many Indians and their Kashmiri collaborators as they could in Srinagar. That swiftly changed the nature of what had begun as an Azaadi revolution into a terrorist jihadi movement. Indian police and soldiers in Kashmir retaliated in kind, armed with draconian new powers under the Special Powers and Terrorism Acts and Disruptive Activities (Prevention) Acts to "shoot on sight" anyone suspected of "disloyal" activities. The number of Kashmiris killed in the Vale escalated rapidly, but in addition to numerous Muslim deaths, most of the politically influential Hindu pandit population of Kashmir, which in 1989 was estimated to number 130,000, were driven out of the Vale and terrorized to flee south to Jammu, where many still must live in crowded, filthy refugee camps without privacy or adequate medical care.

India launched its most intense counterinsurgency catch-and-kill strategy in Kashmir in the early 1990s. Tens of thousands of young Kashmiris "disappeared" from the Vale by 1994, many of them caught by LeT terrorists and another ISI-trained group of armed Muslims, Hizb-ul-Mujahideen (HM). As bloodshed spread through every alley and lane of Srinagar, older Kashmiris turned hostile to the revolt they had initially supported. Innocents were daily gunned down in the lethal cross-fire between troops and terrorists. Criminals and thugs joined the Azaadi revolt, which gave them courage and excuses to steal food and vital supplies from respectable store owners, who shook their heads in disgust at this new definition of "freedom."